The Unending Quest For EXCELLENCE

As the India Today Group's Best Colleges Survey enters its 30th edition, 30 insights on how this comprehensive guide charts the country's higher education landscape

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NO. 1 COLLEGES IN INDIA

STREAM	COLLEGE
ARTS	HINDU COLLEGE, New Delhi
SCIENCE	HINDU COLLEGE, New Delhi
COMMERCE	SHRI RAM COLLEGE OF COMMERCE, New Delhi
MEDICAL	ALL INDIA INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL SCIENCES, New Delhi
DENTAL	MAULANA AZAD INSTITUTE OF DENTAL SCIENCES, New Delhi
ENGINEERING (Government)	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY DELHI, New Delhi
ENGINEERING (Private)	BIRLA INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY AND SCIENCE, Pilani
ARCHITECTURE	DEPARTMENT OF ARCHITECTURE AND PLANNING, IIT ROORKEE, Roorkee
LAW	NATIONAL LAW SCHOOL OF INDIA UNIVERSITY, Bengaluru
MASS COMMUNICATION	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MASS COMMUNICATION, New Delhi
HOTEL MANAGEMENT	INSTITUTE OF HOTEL MANAGEMENT, CATERING & NUTRITION, PUSA, New Delhi
BBA	SHAHEED SUKHDEV COLLEGE OF BUSINESS STUDIES, New Delhi
BCA	CHRIST (DEEMED TO BE UNIVERSITY), Bengaluru
SOCIAL WORK	TATA INSTITUTE OF SOCIAL SCIENCES, Mumbai
FASHION DESIGN	NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF FASHION TECHNOLOGY, New Delhi

For millions of young Indians, college offers more than a degree, it opens the door to better earnings, wider exposure, professional networks, social confidence and the ability to move across regions, industries and class boundaries. In a country nearing the peak of its demographic dividend, higher education remains central to both individual mobility and national ambition. Yet the meaning of a college degree has changed. The job market is tougher, technology is reshaping skills and graduate unemployment remains worryingly high. A degree today must be backed by sound pedagogy, relevant curriculum, practical training, internships, credible assessment and real links with employers.

That is why choosing the right college has become as important as choosing the right course. That decision can shape a young person's professional aspiration, and also determine whether the family's financial investment culminates in value or regret. The difference between government and private fees can be enormous, especially in medicine, engineering, law, design and architecture. In this landscape, the India Today Group's Best Colleges Survey, now in its 30th year, provides a vital public service. Built on innovation, accuracy and credibility, it serves as a trusted yardstick for students, parents, teachers and other stakeholders to assess India's college ecosystem. By looking beyond reputation to faculty quality, infrastructure, diversity, fees, funding, internships, placements, academic progression and campus life, the survey, conducted by Delhi-based market research agency MDRA, helps families separate performance and ambition from advertisement.

When this survey began, India had a fraction of the colleges it has today and almost no independent way to compare them. Today, with more than 50,000 colleges in the country, the choice is bewildering, and the stakes exceptionally high. Continually widening and refining its scope in the past 30 years, the survey has added new disciplines, separated government and